Chapter Six

A Short Truce

"There is not one single place built in this country that did not have a former Arab population."

—Moshe Dayan

The UN-sponsored truce beginning on June 11 contained clauses that specifically forbade any of those involved from using the ceasefire to improve military positions or to bring in reinforcements or additional supplies. This stipulation was completely ignored by everyone involved.

The Israeli Air Force was given a notable boost when a deal was concluded with Czechoslovakia to supply over twenty Supermarine Spitfire fighter bombers. Even in 1948, the Spitfire was still one of the best combat aircraft in the world, and the arrival of these aircraft in September would transform the Israeli Air Force. This boost was further supplemented by another deal concluded during the ceasefire that saw Israel acquire three B-17 Flying Fortress bombers, also from Czechoslovakia. When these arrived in July, they would give the IDF the ability to carry out strategic bombing attacks for the first time. At the same time, clandestine supplies of small arms and ammunition continued to arrive in Israel from Czechoslovakia and were rushed to units at the front.

However, one incident that happened during the ceasefire sparked significant controversy among the Israelis. While Haganah had been largely integrated into the IDF, the other Jewish militant groups, including Irgun, were resistant. While the ceasefire was in effect, it was discovered that members of Irgun had concluded a private deal that would see a large consignment of arms and ammunition arriving on a chartered cargo ship, the *Altalena*. Fearing that this might be a precursor to an attempt at a coup by Irgun, Prime Minister Ben-Gurion ordered that this shipment be intercepted and confiscated by the IDF. The resulting action saw the